tory 'virtual auctions' describing the anatomy of Hindu and Muslim women and tips on how to rape them. The accounts, with fake names like 'KiraXD' and 'Bismillah' and fake photographs, were deactivated later. A Mumbai-based woman who was active in the chats led the police to other accounts and finally to KiraXD. On January 21, Karandikar's team arrested Jaishnav Kakkar, 21, and Yash Parashar, 22, from Faridabad and Akash Suyal, 19, from Karnal, Haryana. Kakkar and Parashar were students of commerce and law, respectively. Suyal had completed his Class 12.

Karandikar, a student of sociology and anthropology and a trained ethical hacker, says all social media platforms "must have an algorithm that factors in women's safety and identifies and tags 'malcontent'...it's their responsibility". She also feels "cyber education" is crucial. "Social media is now an integral part of our psychology. People who wouldn't use derogatory words against women in physical interactions, use such vulgar language on social media," she says. Karandikar, whose team is 60 per cent female, says her biggest takeaway from the 'Bulli Bai' case is that "a message has gone out to criminals that we will catch you, no matter what".

TECHNOCRAT COP

When Amitabh Gupta was appointed Pune police commissioner in August 2020, many had doubts whether the soft-spoken, affable IPS officer was up to the task. A year-and-a-half later, Gupta, a gold medallist from IIT-Kanpur, has proved them all wrong. He has not only done a 'cleansing operation' of criminals in the city but also exposed three state recruitment scams, maybe the biggest in Maharashtra so far.

Gupta overhauled the Pune Police cyber cell, expanding the number of units from two to five and training over 100 officers in investigating cyber crimes. In October 2021, complaints regarding question paper leaks in the health department's recruitment drive were filed in Pune, Beed, Latur and Aurangabad, but it was the Pune police who initiated the investigation. By December end, 19 people had been arrested in the case.

Acting on a tip-off, Gupta's team also exposed another recruitment scam in MHADA (Maharashtra Housing and Development Authority) on December 12, 2021. The Maharashtra government had outsourced the work of conducting the exam to a private firm, G.A. Solution Technologies. The Pune police arrested its director Pritish Deshmukh and two others and retrieved a laptop and pen drive that contained exam-related documents.

Gupta's investigation also led to the uncovering of another recruitment scam in the Teachers Eligibility Test (TET) conducted in 2018 and 2020. The perpetrators 'upgraded' the mark sheet of candidates for a fee. At the height of the scam, several candidates were even delivered bogus pass certificates. One of the candidates had noted the questions and answers on a paper, clicked its picture and sent it to his cousin. That was the moment the leaked paper was digitally transported for the first time and was enough evidence for the cyber cell to zero in on the culprits.

The success in the Bulli Bai and other cases has been a shot in the arm for the Maharashtra police, which has seen top officials caught in unsavoury situations

The Pune police made the first arrest in the case on December 26, 2021, a week after the FIR was registered. "The scam was so widespread that 47 per cent of the candidates who took the exam had paid money to get their marks fixed," says Gupta. A total of 16,705 candidates had appeared for the TET in January 2020; 7,880 passed the exam. The accused had taken an average Rs 3 lakh from a candidate, making it the state's biggest-ever recruitment scam. Twenty-three people have been arrested so far.

Gupta's mettle was tested when the name of an IAS official, Sushil Khodwekar, cropped up in the case. The cyber cell had accessed the WhatsApp records of an accused, Abhijit Savrikar, when they came upon the chats between him and the agriculture department deputy secretary. Gupta says the conversation pertains to the money exchanged in the case; Khodwekar was previously deputy secretary, school education and sports department. His arrest on January 29 sent shockwaves through the state bureaucracy.

Gupta had earlier served in Naxal-affected Gadchiroli and Osmanabad. His initiative, '*Ek gaanv, ek Ganpati* (One Ganesh idol per village)' while he was Osmanabad SP was widely appreciated as a measure to reduce noise and water pollution during Ganeshotsav. The initiative was replicated in several other parts of the state. In Pune, he has done wonders to popularise the Twitter handle @punecitypolice, while 'My Safe Pune', an initiative in which women can mark unsafe spots in the city, has also been a success.

Gupta has also taken some hits, especially in his earlier stint as principal secretary (home). He issued a travel pass to tainted builder Rakesh Wadhawan, an accused in the PMC Bank scam, during the national lockdown in April 2020, for which he was sent on compulsory leave. Gupta was absolved with a clean chit later.

An avid trekker and swimmer, Gupta says gangsters are the real threat in the state but admits that the common man is more worried about street crimes and traffic congestion. "The police have to be people-friendly and also be aware of social media mores these days," he says. The anonymity of the internet is proving to be a great incentive for crime. ■